



ANDREW HARNIK Getty Images

PRESIDENT Trump, who took over Kennedy Center’s board, will be the first president to host its big event.

Making a whole host of changes

The president names this year’s Kennedy Center honorees, and says he will emcee.

By JESSICA GELT

Bucking tradition once again, President Trump on Wednesday announced his picks for Kennedy Center Honors and said he will host the ceremony himself — a first for any president.

Actor and filmmaker Sylvester Stallone, glam-rock band KISS, disco singer Gloria Gaynor, country music star George Strait and English actor and comedian Michael Crawford made the list.

The Kennedy Center Honors, which recognize lifetime achievement in the performing arts, have been given annually since 1978 and are the highlight of the center’s season each December. The award is considered a career milestone for the performers who receive it. Past honorees include Leonard Bernstein, Dizzy Gillespie, Lucille Ball, James Brown, Mel Brooks, Paul McCartney and Meryl Streep, among others.

“I want to congratulate all the nominees. They’re unbelievable people, and we’re going to have a tremendous day in December,” Trump said in a rambling news conference that began with him unveiling five velvet-draped portraits. He went on to mention his recent deployment of the National Guard to Washington, D.C., his contention that the 2020 election was stolen, his disdain for Democrats and his upcoming meeting

[See Kennedy, A14]

Is Putin laying a U.S. trap?

Experts worry Alaska summit will cost Ukraine. But Trump may yet throw a curveball at Russia.

By MICHAEL WILNER

ANCHORAGE — The first presidential summit in years between Russia and the United States is on, setting nerves in Europe and Ukraine on a knife’s edge. But President Trump may have a surprise in store for Vladimir Putin.

Efforts to scuttle the high-stakes meeting have not been subtle. European officials issued statements in recent days on the futility of Trump negotiating with Putin over Ukraine without Ukraine, urging the U.S. president on Wednesday to not cut a unilateral deal. Kyiv warned that Moscow’s proposals for peace — rewarding its war of conquest with territorial concessions — are a nonstarter. Many Russia experts are hoping one side simply decides to call it off.

Despite their efforts, the summit — haphazardly scheduled on American soil with days to spare — is moving ahead, with Trump scheduled to host the Russian leader at a U.S. military base in Anchorage on Friday, the first meeting of its kind since 2021.

Experts fear Putin may be laying a trap for the Americans, manipulating

Trump in private to solidify Russia’s position on the battlefield. But Trump suggested Wednesday that he would demand Putin agree to a ceasefire in Alaska.

“There will be very severe consequences” if he doesn’t, Trump told reporters.

Hosting the meeting is an about-face from Trump, who over much of the summer appeared in the throes of a remarkable transformation on Putin, criticizing the Russian leader in harsh terms for the first time. To the relief and delight of Europe, Trump appeared to be losing his patience — embarrassed, even — at Putin’s open refusal to heed his calls for a ceasefire in Ukraine.

But Trump’s threats of a response, increasing sanctions against Russia and its trading partners, lasted only a matter of days.

On Aug. 6, the president’s special envoy on the crisis, Steve Witkoff, a real estate investor with no experience in diplomacy and no background in the region, was dispatched to Moscow. Plan

[See Summit, A6]

Central Valley home values sink with the land

By IAN JAMES AND GRACE TOOHEY

In parts of the San Joaquin Valley, sinking land has become such a serious problem, it is beginning to depress home prices, new research shows.

Homes in large portions of California’s Central Valley have been sinking, as have roads, bridges, canals and levees, as too much water is drawn out of underground aquifers.

Now researchers at UC Riverside have found that home sale prices are 2.4% to 5.4% lower than they would be if the land were stable,

translating to per-home losses of \$6,689 to \$16,165. The paper looks at sales between 2015 and 2021.

Mehdi Nemati, a UC Riverside assistant professor of environmental economics and policy who led the study, said his team knew that sinking land was already affecting homes and homeowners across the Central Valley, with cracking foundations, dry wells, higher insurance premiums and increased stress. But he said they were startled by their results.

“We were surprised because land subsidence is not like flooding or wildfires,”

[See Sinking, A7]



TOMAS OVALLE For The Times

SUBSIDENCE due to overpumping of water in the Central Valley has hurt home prices, a study found.

How wild carjackings and chase unfolded

In a rare case for L.A., thieves managed to get away. Sources say there may be helpers.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

They may end up being the ones that got away.

A wild police pursuit Sunday was already notable for its dramatic twists and turns. Authorities say two suspects carjacked a truck in Lancaster and opened fire on its owner before the police gave chase. In the hours that followed, they stole two more vehicles before ending up in a Chevrolet Silverado under a freeway overpass in Boyle Heights, shielded from the police and TV helicopters overhead.

Then things got really strange. The two suspects appear to have escaped in another car with the help of accomplices, according to law enforcement sources. Three days later, they are still at large.

“It’s obvious that they were well versed on the region, the area,” said Art Acevedo, a former California Highway Patrol section chief who has decades of experience in pursuits. The suspects used tactics Acevedo says are “completely aggressive, really reckless and highly dangerous.”

L.A. has long been obsessed with police pursuits, which are regularly televised across TV and the web. They have become the cornerstone of key cultural moments, led by the O.J. Simp

[See Pursuit, A7]

Airbnb confirms role in Save Our Services L.A. flier campaign

By NOAH GOLDBERG

When Marni Lustig saw a flier for the Save Our Services campaign, she didn’t immediately grasp what she was reading.

The flier appeared to be about Los Angeles’ budget crisis, potential layoffs of city workers and possible cuts to public services.

Then, she spotted a sentence about expanding short-term rentals and realized the campaign applied directly to her.

Lustig wants to buy a home and rent it through Airbnb, but the city allows short-term rentals only for primary residences. The campaign aims to legalize Airbnb and similar rentals for second homes, which, according to supporters, would generate tax revenue

to help address the budget crisis.

“Because we’re not allowed to [rent out second homes] here, I’ve been looking outside of the city. So they’ll get my money, not L.A.,” said Lustig, a fashion photographer who lives in a Pico-Robertson rental that she lists on Airbnb.

In the last few weeks, residents around the city have been flooded with fliers hung on their doors and canvassers polling them about Save Our Services. Some of the fliers don’t mention short-term rentals and describe only the budget crisis while including a QR code for the campaign’s website.

That website paints a grim picture of the city’s finances and proposes a solution: allowing “a limited number of people to rent

[See Fliers, A11]



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

SMITH EYES A BATTING TITLE

Dodgers catcher could fall short of the number of plate appearances needed as team provides him rest down the stretch, Bill Shaikin writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Case tests limits on Trump’s clout

Trial on deployment of National Guard is a bellwether for the rule of law. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

UFW fight clouds nursery’s closure

Company says site was losing money. Others say layoffs sent a clear message. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather Clearing.

L.A. Basin: 81/64. **B6**



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